The Case for Youth in Politics | HE Omar Sultan Al Olama (One of the World's Youngest Ministers)

(0:17 - 0:22)

There are a lot of fast cars in Dubai. This doesn't sound fast, by the way. No, it's not, no.

(0:30 - 0:50)

Nikhil will always sit like this. Without further ado, the two stars of this evening, His Excellency Omar Sultan Al-Ulama and Nikhil Thamat. Thank you.

(1:07 - 1:23)

It's, I don't know if Manoj wanted to stress this out, but the month started with Elon, then Sam, then Ray Dalio. I'm sorry you're getting the disappointment at the very end, towards the end of the month, but let's give them a good show. No, thank you.

(1:24 - 1:42)

In this region, I have learned nobody sits above the royal family and anybody wearing an attire like yours. And this has been reinforced so many times over the last one week. So I'd like to thank you for taking the time to do this.

(1:43 - 2:09)

And to learn at how you look at technology from the lens of this region, I think will be very interesting for a city that to many of us seems almost like an extension of India today. So maybe we can start off with that. What has you most excited? What excites me the most, to be very honest, I think we're at the beginning of something incredible.

(2:10 - 2:21)

A country of 10 million people cannot compete today with a country of a billion people. It's impossible. Physics determines that there's a certain size where you can't really compete.

(2:22 - 2:43)

However, with AI, I think we will have the ability to punch way above our weight and we will be able to sit on the table with the larger countries. If you're able to produce a lot more, if you're able to be a lot more productive, a lot more intelligent, you will be able to be taken seriously regardless of your size. And this is something that is important to us.

(2:44 - 3:10)

The comparison is the comparison today of those who embrace AI wholeheartedly versus those who embrace AI with a lot of red tape and a lot of nuances. The difference is going to be between a community that still lives on wood fire versus a community that lives in the 21st century with electricity and internet. It's going to be incomparable.

(3:11 - 3:20)

That's what excites me. When you spoke about Sam, Elon, and everybody else, they have virtual money, you have real money. It's a big difference.

(3:24 - 3:34)

Well, you know, it's interesting. Many billionaires are billionaires on paper. Like many of the people I know, it's not real.

(3:34 - 3:52)

Well, I don't want to comment on your friends, but what I will say, the industries we are in, whether it's logistics, whether it's tourism, whether it's banking and others, are where there is real money. However, it's not about how much money you have. It's about how much impact you can create.

(3:52 - 4:01)

There are countries that are much, much richer that can't create half the impact that we can. And I think that's what really matters to us. You're 35, Your Excellency.

(4:02 - 4:25)

I'm a few years older than you, 39. The generation which came after us, I think 28 and below, probably experiences Dunning-Kruger the most because they all might know very little, but they're commenting on the world like they know a lot. That is the society of tomorrow.

(4:26 - 4:48)

And that is also the society of Dubai and society of India. Where on the curve are you today? And if you had to tell that society something, what would you say? From 10 years of having lived for longer than they have? Excellent question. I think, so the first point I'm going to say is, let's determine.

(4:48 - 5:03)

So you're determining where we are and where they are. Let's determine who is the best generation. Is it us? Is it them? I genuinely believe the best generation is the generations that are between 60 today and 40 years old.

(5:04 - 5:27)

Why is that? I think there is something very interesting that happened because of the internet and because of AI and all of these tools that we have. That we lost something called the breadth of intelligence that people had to get by and to live their daily lives in the past. So I don't think we're much better.

(5:27 - 5:34)

We are better maybe because the technology came in later in our lives. So you're 39, I'm 34 or 35. I wish I'm 34.

(5:36 - 5:42)

So wait till you're 39. Well, I'm dreading 36. So let's take it step by step.

(5:43 - 5:58)

But, you know, we actually don't know a lot of things that one generation older than us knows. And that one generation above us don't know a lot of things that the generation before them knows. And it's not because of age.

(5:59 - 6:17)

The challenge, I think, is the necessity of life at the time requires that you understand everything. Understand the environment, understand the nature, understand the technology of what's around you. And then get by having this incredible, you know, breadth of intelligence and applying it to the field that you want.

(6:17 - 6:26)

So you see people that were uneducated that could build billion-dollar companies, right? We can see that in the UAE. I'm sure there are examples in India. There are examples in the US.

(6:27 - 6:45)

With this hyper-focused and specialized world that we're living in today because of technology, I feel like unfortunately, you know, AI is going to beat us to the target. If we have to be hyper-specialized, AI can do that better than us. The only way you can stand the chance is if you have the breadth of knowledge.

(6:46 - 7:14)

So my advice to those people who are 10 years younger is move from being intelligence-specific to being broad intelligence. Everyone uses, you know, the verse from Shakespeare's poem, a

jack of all trades is a master of none. But no one actually continues that verse because the second verse after it says, but most times better than a master of one.

(7:16 - 7:35)

Very interesting. If I were a jack of all trades in five years from now, what job would I do? Let's flip the question around. If you were a master of one, what job will you have in five years? And I'm sure you can't really think of a job.

(7:37 - 7:56)

I feel like the easiest of jobs will get replaced late. So I think if I were a plumber, my job would probably last longer than if I were a plumber in the Maslow's Law of Hierarchy in a way. I don't think you can say this with absolute conviction.

(7:56 - 8:04)

But with AI, I feel like nobody can say anything. What I'm saying is we are speculating. So your chances are higher if you know more things.

(8:04 - 8:29)

Right? Because since we are speculating, because we are not sure what is going to happen, the chances of someone who knows a little bit of many things are higher than the chances of someone who knows something very specific. Like if you are a master accountant, the best accountant in the world, right? Your chances are going to be much lower than someone who knows a lot of different things. It doesn't mean that if AI takes the accounting job, you're doomed.

(8:30 - 8:40)

I'm sure there are going to be other jobs. I'll tell you a funny story. So this morning on my way to work, I opened up Instagram because someone sent me a link.

(8:41 - 8:56)

And the first video that came out, I think I saved it, was Rent a Friend in Dubai. So what was funny was there was a Dubai run. So the Dubai run, 300,000 people ran this marathon in Dubai on Sheikh Zayed Road.

(8:56 - 9:12)

And you could see, you could actually rent someone to run with you in the Dubai marathon and you pay an amount of money for that. So I looked at all the different things that they have. So every group activity, you want to play paddle, but you don't have three friends.

(9:12 - 9:22)

Paddle tennis, you don't have three friends to play with you. You can rent three friends and they will come and they will actually act as if they know you. They'll keep praising you and saying you're such a good player.

(9:22 - 9:31)

Some of them will lose just so you win. So the thing is, okay, this service existed in Japan for a while. It existed in Korea.

(9:31 - 9:47)

It's now moving around the world. Why? Because we are gaining a lot with productivity improvement of AI, but we're losing a lot with social interaction. So even this accountant that will lose his job will probably be a Rent a Friend somewhere in the world.

(9:49 - 10:00)

In a way, the jobs of before will come back. Like the oldest professions of the world. I think, so I don't think things get repeated the exact same way.

(10:00 - 10:32)

But I think it will have certain features from things that existed in the past. Your Excellency, if you had to redraw your country, from the eyes of a 35-year-old politician, if there is something that politicians half your age are not doing and they should be doing, what would you say that is? One thing they should be focusing on that they're not focusing on. I had a very interesting experience.

(10:33 - 10:47)

And I think I can claim that it was a unique experience. So no other minister in the world went through this experience. So the experience I had was after serving in the government for three years.

(10:47 - 10:58)

So we have in the UAE mandatory military service. So you have to go and serve in the military. Historically, no minister anywhere on earth has served while being minister.

(10:58 - 11:17)

Why is that interesting? So it's interesting for three reasons. The first is I actually lived two lives in the same day. So the moment I go into the camp, I am the smallest insect in that camp.

(11:17 - 11:32)

I'm a cadet, not like everyone else. And the moment I leave the doors, I'm more senior than the highest ranking officer in that camp, right? So for the first few months, actually, no one knew I was a minister. No one.

(11:34 - 11:47)

And over time, it started to come out. So the interesting thing about that experience was it was a very grounding experience. I remember sitting with a group of young men.

(11:47 - 11:57)

And so we were sitting together on the hot tarmac. It was so hot. And I remember, so we were talking and I looked at them.

(11:58 - 12:12)

I was like, what do you guys think of what's happening in the AI in the UAE? And one of them looked at me. He said, you're an idiot. I said, why? He said, we're sitting here on this hot tarmac, only thinking about our next meal.

(12:12 - 12:30)

And you're talking to us about AI? Get a life. And why was that, you know, life-changing moment? I realized what really matters to people is the next bite. What really matters to people is first the basic necessities.

(12:31 - 12:48)

And as a government, we need to operate to first fulfill that, then look at things like AI and other things, you know, because you typically as a politician only look at your mandate as the most important mandate in the world. Nothing else matters, right? So I only see that AI is the most important thing. And this was the wake-up call.

(12:49 - 13:00)

Because in that moment, I realized this has to always be the second priority. The first is the things that people need on a daily basis. The second is AI and everything else.

(13:01 - 13:11)

First of all, wow, what a fantastic discussion. This is nothing but an intellectual juggle, Bandi. So congratulations to both of you.

(13:11 - 13:27)

It was absolutely fascinating. I want to say thank you, but by divulging a secret about Omar. So just on the way here, about 15 minutes before we reached, Omar called me, said, Manoj Shah, and his voice was very down, etc.

(13:28 - 13:35)

I'm not feeling very well. And then he paused and then he said, but I'm coming. And I'm going to be here with you guys.

(13:35 - 14:03)

And that's why it makes it so much more special. Thank you. Thank you for doing this two days in a row, Your Excellency.

(14:03 - 14:24)

Last night, we caught up. And I think the conversation I was surprised by, you were so articulate in things, which I don't expect for a politician, a generic politician to be. I almost don't look at you like a politician right now.

(14:24 - 14:47)

I look at you as a young man who's 35, who has a very nuanced, different approach to life, policymaking, and how this region is doing today and how it will do tomorrow. So thank you for doing this with me for the second day in a row. And hopefully today will be better than the night before.

(14:47 - 15:09)

Well, I don't know if the bar was low for yesterday, but hopefully we'll have a fun conversation. So my audience is largely young entrepreneurs, wannabe entrepreneurs in India. A lot of them are aspiring to build really cool startups in tech, start businesses in different domains.

(15:09 - 15:18)

So I'm going to ask you questions which are largely from their lens. First thing, we don't know your story. Maybe we can begin there.

(15:18 - 15:36)

If you could tell us a little bit about how you got to be who you are today at 35, which is extremely young in our lens for a politician, the path that led you to where you sit today. Maybe we can start there. Thank you very much.

(15:36 - 15:51)

I hope that the story is relevant and hopefully it inspires some people. I believe that whether it's power or money, whatever you have, if you wield it in the right way, you can have the right impact. Some people have a lot of money.

(15:52 - 15:56)

They don't wield it in the right way. It means nothing. Some people have a lot of power.

(15:56 - 16:13)

They wield it in the wrong way. It leads to a bad reputation, corruption, being considered a tyrant or whatever you want to consider it. So I don't think it's about either or, right? Anything you have, if you wield it in the right way, you're able to really create great impact with it.

(16:14 - 16:32)

Why I mentioned the story is at that point, I had a few business ventures that I worked on post that point across my life in school and then university. But at that point, I said to myself, I don't want to become a minister. What I want to be is I want to become the richest man in the world.

(16:33 - 16:50)

And I thought that money was the right thing to have because money could be used and utilized to create any impact that you want to have. This all changed on a flight to Rome. So we were flying to the Vatican many years post that.

(16:51 - 17:12)

And on the flight, I was with a minister in our government. His name is Mohammad Gargawi. And in that meeting on the flight, he said to me, Omar, what do you want to do in your life? What's next for you? I told him, Can I ask just for context, why were you on a flight with a minister going to the Vatican? Okay, that's a great question.

(17:12 - 17:35)

I was trying to skip that part, but I'll tell you. So Pope Francis sent a letter to His Highness Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid at the time asking Sheikh Mohammed why Dubai has 200 nationalities living in Dubai without any conflicts. And he said, what are lessons that the world can learn from Dubai? This was actually in the beginning of his period as Pope.

(17:36 - 17:47)

And His Highness Sheikh Mohammed told Minister Gargawi to go and see Pope Francis and to

just explain to him what is the secret sauce of Dubai. And the secret sauce is actually no secret sauce. It's the fact that everyone's treated equally and fairly.

(17:47 - 17:58)

Everyone feels equally represented. Everyone feels like tomorrow is going to be better than today. So it's these factors that give people equal opportunity amongst others that might be adversaries in other places.

(17:59 - 18:06)

Here, they're considered equals. So we were in the airplane. I was actually his plus one, like I was his entourage.

(18:06 - 18:18)

So he asked me on the flight this question. I told him I want to be the richest man in the world. And he said to me, Omar, why do you want to be the richest man in the world? And I told him, I believe that if I have the money, I'll be able to enact positive change.

(18:19 - 18:27)

So if I see someone that needs money, I'll give him the money. And hopefully that will change his life. If I want to improve education, I'll start my own school.

(18:27 - 18:40)

If I want to help with health care, I'll start my own hospital and so on and so forth. And he asked me a question. He said, what's more important, money, knowledge or network? I looked at him and I said, money.

(18:41 - 18:52)

He said, wrong. If you have all the money in the world, but you don't have the knowledge or the network, you'll spend that money, you'll go bankrupt because you don't have the knowledge. And that's it.

(18:53 - 19:07)

So I told him the knowledge is the most important. He said, no, if you have all the knowledge in the world, but you don't have the money or the network, then it's going to stay in your head. There are so many smart people in different places around the world that are so smart, but can't really do much with their knowledge.

(19:08 - 19:22)

So I asked him, I said, what's the answer? He said, the answer is network. If you have the right network, you will be able to access money and you will be able to access knowledge. And with that, you will be able to enact change.

(19:23 - 19:42)

And he said, this is what government offers that nowhere else can you find. In the government, you can build the right network to be able to enact change, whether it's with your own money or through rallying the right people to do the right thing. And this was life changing.

(19:42 - 20:20)

If I may interject, why impact? As a young person who grew up to a father who worked in the army and a principal mother and went to really expensive schools out there, I'm guessing these schools taught capitalism in a manner. They're Western education, right? Yes. Why did you go from there to this point where you wanted to create an impact as you grow older? I think that my parents instilled in all of us is the fact that we should know our roots.

(20:20 - 20:40)

We should know where we came from. We should know what our fathers, our forefathers, our ancestors did for us to reach this point. And I believe, as many other people believe, that I come from a family who has a stellar reputation in creating impact wherever they go.

(20:40 - 20:59)

So my grandfather had profound impact on my country, on the broader region, on our religion, on other things. So my grandfather was a religious preacher. And he was a man that most people speak very highly of to this day.

(21:00 - 21:28)

And you see a lot of people that have a lot of money or at one point had a lot of power. After they pass away, you look at them and you say, you know, his era has ended and you don't really remember them for the right things. But those who've had the right impact, whether it's the right impact with the knowledge that they bestowed on the world, with the money that they invested in creating positive impact, with just being a person that was a delightful person to deal with, are remembered beyond their lifetime.

(21:29 - 21:45)

And this is one thing that I think all of us in our household want. I want to be remembered as a person that has changed the world after I've been part of it for the better. It could be because of the interactions I had, because of the knowledge I was able to bestow on others, because of the

work that I did.

(21:46 - 21:59)

And you know, I'm feeling it today. This building that we're on right now, the Museum of the Future, was a nightmare that I worked on for a few years. You know, there are so many sleepless nights because this was such a complicated project.

(21:59 - 22:28)

But the fact that I had a small part to play in something as iconic, as important as this, is something that's going to stay with me and my family for eternity. And that's what I think we should all strive for, impact rather than just, you know, short-term gains. When you read philosophy, if I were to say read... I don't think Marcus Aurelius wrote a book, but he... He did, he wrote Meditations.

(22:28 - 23:00)

Yeah, I think it was his journal which was converted into a book almost. But someone like him said, how does it matter what happens beyond his time? Even if you rule the world, even if you're the best ruler of the world and you have your statues in every street like Alexander did maybe, 50 years beyond Alexander having gone away, nobody will likely remember Alexander. A few people might in 50, but in 500 they won't.

(23:01 - 23:35)

So if I might ask you, Your Excellency, if I may call you Omar, why does it matter what happens to your name beyond your time? So it's ironic that you mentioned Marcus Aurelius, even though he said that, he is remembered beyond his time, right? So we still talk about him today, a few thousand years after he passed away. And I think this is what we need to strive for. You shouldn't strive for being remembered for the wrong reasons or for being remembered for the sake of remembrance.

(23:35 - 23:50)

You have to be remembered by the value you create. And I don't want to get too philosophical, but someone like Hitler, Adolf Hitler is remembered, right? He's remembered more than 50 years after he passed away. I think he's lesser so today than he was 50 years ago.

(23:50 - 24:20)

And I think in 100 years, you think he'll be remembered? I still think he's going to be remembered. So there are individuals that are remembered because of the wrong things, right? So it's not necessarily always positive. But if you are able to really create something new, why I mentioned

the Museum of the Future, as long as this structure stands, those who were part of its creation are going to be remembered, right? So I could have worked on any structure.

(24:20 - 24:32)

I could have worked on any of these buildings that are around us. You know, these buildings are just blocks like any other building that you might see. The person who worked on Burj Khalifa is going to be remembered, right? Because it's an icon, as long as it still stands.

(24:33 - 24:43)

Now, there are other things that are more important. And that is the knowledge that you create in that journey. Someone like Machiavelli.

(24:43 - 25:05)

Now, he's remembered on more of a cynical and negative sense. But still, you know, the impact he's had on a certain political science and content is remembered to this day. Do you resonate with Machiavelli? Look, I think Machiavelli brought a side of political science that was unexplored or undiscussed before he was there.

(25:06 - 25:15)

I don't think I resonate or not resonate. I think it's important to know all knowledge. And then with knowing it, try to create your own path, right? So I've read The Prince.

(25:16 - 25:27)

I've read Meditations by Marcus Aurelius. I've read... Actually, Machiavelli had a strange distinction that he lasted through the times of many different rulers, in a way. He survived.

(25:28 - 25:43)

So if you were to be Machiavelli, who would be the Medicis? Look, the world is very different to the time of Machiavelli. And the time of Machiavelli, the world was going through transformations. So Europe has just left the Dark Ages.

(25:44 - 25:51)

They were going through the Renaissance. The center of the world was Florence. The Medicis were the financiers of the world.

(25:52 - 26:03)

So I think it's a very unique situation that he found himself in. And he was a person who wanted to survive. For him, I think the only thing he could have done was being the advisor.

(26:03 - 26:17)

So this is why survival was important for him. We live in a world today that is very different because the opportunities that are out there for any individual that has a certain amount of talent are endless. You are a person that's doing podcasts today.

(26:18 - 26:37)

If this venture doesn't continue, or if you choose to do something else tomorrow, I'm sure there are 10 or 100 other things that you can do and you'll still be successful, right? Because the internet has opened up certain opportunities for us. The fact that we can go to any part of the world and find opportunities. AI has opened certain opportunities for us.

(26:37 - 26:50)

The fact that India is a booming center of the world today. All of these things open up opportunities. So I don't think today in a place like the UAE or in a place like India, you will have one Machiavelli.

(26:51 - 27:14)

People look at Machiavelli and look at the manipulator, right? I'm sure there are many manipulators in the world. And the Medici's, the people that are being manipulated, depending on who the manipulator is, are in different things, in politics, in media, in entrepreneurship and in business and so on and so forth. But I think those who go about in their life getting what they want through manipulation don't survive for long.

(27:15 - 27:36)

It's not a sustainable way to actually survive in this ecosystem because those who survive are those who actually create value that goes beyond this specific task that they have. And maybe this is something we can touch upon later. If you look at jobs, jobs are going to be displaced if people are only good for one specific thing.

(27:36 - 28:05)

If you're just good at manipulating people, at one point of time, something's going to change and you're going to be out of a job. But if you are good at learning, if you're good at being a renaissance man, and this is maybe relevant because Medici is the topic of discussion. If you are a person who has skills and knowledge about many different topics under a very broad umbrella, you will be relevant regardless of the technology, regardless of the geography and regardless of the time.

(28:06 - 28:36)

You know, if I were to look back at The Prince, the book you mentioned, and think of what I remember from it, he said a very interesting thing. He said, a prince must always appear to be generous philanthropy, family man, religious, forgiving. But then he finished the statement with, a prince must always appear to be these things, but never actually be these things.

(28:37 - 29:08)

He mentions, maybe if I'll have a stab at remembering that part, he mentions that the prince needs to be feared as one of the elements. The prince of the time of Machiavelli required all of these things. Because if you remember, at that point of time, if you've read the history of the time, a prince was a necessary construct for Florence and for Italy, but princes were changing on a seasonal basis.

(29:09 - 29:19)

There were wars, people were removed, people were put in power. So only the strong princes were those who could stay. And I think Machiavelli understood that.

(29:19 - 30:33)

Now, most people who read his writings, thought that this is universal for all times and for all places, which I think for any content that people generate, you have to understand how to apply that knowledge to your time, what to take from it and what to leave from it, right? So I think he was giving that advice for the right prince at the right moment in that geography. A lot of the other things that he mentioned relating to political science and the political landscape were very interesting, but I don't think it's something that you can consider a universal truth for all times. Do you think the world has changed today? If I were to pick up a piece of pen, a paper, sketch or draw the boundaries of a kingdom, put some people in it, and if I were to depict a prince or a king, and I want the kingdom to last for hundreds of years, is fear a bigger tool for me than love or is love a bigger tool for me than fear? So that's a great philosophical question and I think we have practical answers for it.

(30:34 - 31:14)

Let me first go back to the first point that you mentioned and then answer this question specifically. There's a saying you can trick many people for a short period of time or you can trick a few people for a long period of time, but you can't trick many people for a long period of time. And this is important because if you apply Machiavelli's thinking to any prince that acts philanthropic or acts kind or acts like a family man, especially in our DNA with social media, it's absolutely impossible because you will have one bad moment and it will come out.

(31:15 - 31:31)

Regardless of how you portray yourself, in this time, it's very hard to apply that. And I think in most times, actually, the curtain always opens up and people see through it and see what's behind it. So it's very, very difficult to sustain this for a long period of time.

(31:31 - 31:51)

You can go back to history to see people like Commodus, for example, in the Roman age. He acted brave and he acted kind and he acted generous and so on and so forth, but he couldn't sustain it and people saw through it in a short period of time. Now, without going into history, let's talk about practical realities.

(31:52 - 32:16)

You have different examples from different parts of the world. I'm not going to mention the bad examples in certain geographies, but I'm going to mention some highlights and you can actually come up with your own conclusion. There are people that were born in societies that were extremely wealthy that portrayed themselves, and these are princes, that portrayed themselves as generous and all of that.

(32:16 - 32:34)

But with time, people saw through it and there was a revolt against them in their countries. And there are numerous examples, whether it's in Europe in the beginning of the 20th century or even the end of the 19th century or in different parts of the world. So I think there are numerous examples of that.

(32:34 - 33:04)

There are rare examples that have sustained for many, many centuries that we're seeing, you know, being role models here in the Middle East. So what most people don't know, the Al Maktoums who ruled Dubai have been ruling Dubai since 1833. Not a single one throughout, whatever you can read from history and whatever I'm seeing right now from my interactions with my leadership, not a single one puts on an act.

(33:05 - 33:22)

So, you know, when I work with the science Sheikh Hamdan, what he is on social media is what he is in reality, is what he is on the streets. And people actually are shocked when they see that what you see is what you get. He is kind, he is loving, he is generous and he's all of that.

(33:22 - 33:40)

Because these are people that don't care about perception, they care about legacy. And with that focus on legacy, they understand that their message is far larger than individual. Their legacy is a legacy for a nation, for a people and for a country that will stay for many, many years.

(33:41 - 33:56)

The same is true, many people don't know this fact. So the Al Nahyan family in Abu Dhabi is one of the longest reigning royal families in the world. So they have been reigning for over 300 years.

(33:57 - 34:29)

And what you have to understand, it's very, very hard to continue for a long period of time and get positive results for all of this time. So if you look at Dubai and you look at Dubai from the early 1900s to 2025, there's only one constant, is regardless of the challenges, the trajectory was always up. It wasn't because of oil, but there was always opportunities, pearl trading, being a trading hub, focusing on the internet when no one focused on the internet and so on and so forth.

(34:29 - 34:48)

It's because the system works and because the leaders are able to plan for a legacy rather than plan for an election or plan for a short-term focus. I'm not saying this to try to convince you that our political system works for everyone. I think it works for us and it works perfectly.

(34:49 - 34:59)

And other political systems work in other places. But the righteous prince, the benevolent leaders are going to continue. They continue for 200 years.

(34:59 - 35:34)

I think they're going to continue for longer than that. History has kind of not been testament to that, right? Like you have benevolent leaders for many generations, but how do you ensure that the benevolence continues in perpetuity? Because nobody can control how their kids turn out to be in perpetuity. So, you know, there's a... If you look at the history of the world, the world goes through cycles, cycles of change.

(35:35 - 35:45)

For those who believe in democracy, they will look at the cycles where it's only democracy. But even democracy is changed, right? You know, there is a democracy. It goes back to becoming a monarchy.

(35:46 - 35:56)

It goes back to being a democracy and so on and so forth. You have to understand, first, the

construct of the political system. You have to understand the construct of the society.

(35:57 - 36:28)

You have to understand what the results that are gained from this construct are before understanding whether it's going to last or not. Our political system is very different to the political systems that you think exist elsewhere. Because most people look at our political system and they put a Western lens to it, right? It's very similar to the political system in the UK or the political system in Germany or wherever, when it was a kingdom.

(36:29 - 36:43)

Our political system is built on a few fundamentals. The first is there's a very close bond between the tribes and the leadership. And these close bonds are bonds that are historic.

(36:45 - 37:30)

So the concept of a majlis, where all the families and all the people come and meet with the ruler, is actually the most democratic thing you can see anywhere in the world. The fact that I can see the president of my country, and not just me, another Emirati that lives in Al Ain, that has a small farm, another Emirati that works in a company, can all show up to his majlis, can meet with him, can tell him what they need, can tell him what they think, can tell him, for example, what works for them and what doesn't work for them, is the best system you can ever see anywhere in the world. If you go to meet with the president in many countries, there are so many different hoops and red tape that you have to jump over to get that appointment.

(37:31 - 37:42)

And when you go, it's a photo op and you leave. The majlis happens weekly. Every single week, people go and meet with, you know, the ruler of Dubai or the ruler of Abu Dhabi.

(37:42 - 37:47)

They meet with the president. They actually speak. They sit and see others.

(37:48 - 37:57)

They share ideas. They share concerns. They share insights of what, you know, is happening on the ground.

(37:57 - 38:06)

That most of the times, by the way, people try to ensure that leadership doesn't get these messages. And these things lead to results. And the results today, you can see them.

(38:07 - 38:32)

A country that started in 1971, that had 45, I think, university graduates, being one of the most prosperous nations in the world. The result of that is a result of a system that works. It doesn't just work for the Emiratis because we've benefited greatly, right? You know, you're seeing today, our country is being considered one of the most prosperous countries in the world.

(38:32 - 38:51)

And we're living a great life, you know, and thank God and thankfully because of our leaders. But even those who are non-Emiratis are reaping the benefits of the system. A system where today, to every day, tomorrow is better than the day before it.

(38:52 - 39:05)

In the hardest of times, people are reassured that you'll all be taken care of. When COVID struck, everyone was talking about death. And everyone was talking about pandemics and lockdowns and so on and so forth.

(39:05 - 39:21)

The very first thing I heard from my president was he said, and he did this publicly in front of everyone, he did a majlis and he called people and he said, let's shillun him. Don't carry a single worry. And he didn't say don't carry a single worry if you're Emirati.

(39:22 - 39:30)

He didn't say don't carry a single worry if you're Indian. He didn't say don't carry a single worry if you're rich or poor. He said it for everyone.

(39:31 - 39:39)

And he said, as long as you are on this land, you are taken care of. And it's a very beautiful statement to make. In many countries, they made similar statements and people died anyway.

(39:40 - 39:49)

But there was action that followed and the results that were incredible. And this is what people need to see. Your political system needs to achieve that for you.

(39:49 - 39:59)

This is success. Success is results that don't just cover a certain portion of the population. They don't just cover a certain portion of a social class.

(39:59 - 40:19)

It covers everyone. From the outside looking in, I'm enamored by how exceptionally well this region has done. I think thanks to people like yourself and your predecessors before you.

(40:19 - 41:04)

I'm trying to figure out why. Do you think the system works because there are a million Emiratis and 10 million expats and there are 11 million in the country? Do you think the same political system could work for a hundred million people? Actually, I would argue the system should not work because of this demographic construct. Isn't trust highest in smaller groups? So, you're talking about trusting government or trusting what exactly? When I read books about how political systems have been formed, it feels to me like most people are almost socialist when it comes to their family.

(41:04 - 41:20)

When there are three or four people, they open up a bit more when it goes from their family to their community. And when you talk about a country with millions and millions, in some cases, billions of people, there is no interaction. There is no majlis.

(41:20 - 41:55)

There is no seeing the ruler of the country or whichever country. Even in democratic countries, there are many pockets of power, but there is rarely interaction between somebody living there with the people in a position of power in that geography. So, how do you keep this trust not for a country with a million citizens, but with a billion? So, I'm going to give you an ignorant answer here because this is going to be me assuming that what I'm going to say is going to be applicable to that country.

(41:55 - 42:12)

So, please take it with a grain of salt. I'm going to tell you the hardest thing ever is managing a country where a vast majority of the populace is a populace from every walk of life, from every country in the world. There is a sweet spot.

(42:12 - 42:29)

So, managing a billion people is very difficult. Managing a hundred million people is less difficult. And I think I wouldn't say it's easy, but if you have the right populace, if you have the right country, it actually leads to incredible power and results.

(42:30 - 42:49)

Look at Japan. Today, a country like Japan has a hundred plus million people that are all of the same background, of the same, you know, cultural ethnicity. And there are so many beautiful things about Japan that we all admire when we go and visit, right? We admire how orderly the country is.

(42:50 - 42:59)

We admire how clean it is. We admire how people are thinking of themselves as a collective rather than themselves as individuals. So, there are so many things to admire.

(42:59 - 43:23)

Now, a country like the UAE, where the people that, as you said, are your people are the one million, it's very difficult to achieve similar results to Japan. Because everyone's coming to you with their background, with their culture, with their history, with their understanding, you know. And there are those who are, you know, they believe that they need to keep the country clean.

(43:23 - 43:31)

There are those who think that they can just throw anything out of the window and it doesn't matter. There are those who, you know, are loud. There are those who are quiet.

(43:31 - 44:12)

You have every different type of person. Why does this system work? This system works not because it is easy, but because the right fundamentals were put in place from the get-go. If we didn't do the right thing when the country was established, so the population wasn't 10 million, right? The growth that you're seeing, and the growth that you're seeing even now post all the success, the snowball being even bigger and faster and moving, you know, much more than we did when we first started as a country, means that everyone comes here because the value this country creates for them and for their livelihoods and for their future is higher than being anywhere else on earth.

(44:13 - 44:30)

Today, we're not attracting those who are looking for living paycheck to paycheck. We're attracting every walk of life from the top of the pyramid to the bottom of the pyramid. Look at the Henley index for the migration of high net worth individuals.

(44:30 - 44:47)

So the highest inflow of high net worth individuals in the world was to the UAE and, you know, to Dubai and Abu Dhabi for three years in a row. 10,000. So depending on the year, the number was 10,000, 8,000, 6,000, but higher than anywhere else on the planet.

(44:48 - 44:59)

And those people can afford to live anywhere else on earth. And they can get the best service wherever they go. Why did they choose to come here, right? And the answer isn't size.

(45:00 - 45:13)

The answer is the quality of the product. The quality of the product, as in the government that they're dealing with here is different to any government they would deal with anywhere on earth. I can afford to live anywhere, right? I can afford to pay the taxes.

(45:14 - 45:20)

I can afford to buy the apartments. I can afford to hire the help. The quality of government is better than anywhere else in the world.

(45:20 - 45:33)

The quality of infrastructure is better than anywhere else. And is the quality of government better because of less interference from the government? So government shouldn't be in your face. This is something that we believe in.

(45:34 - 45:52)

Government is here for one purpose. It's here to ensure that your quality of life is better tomorrow than it is today, every single day. And we don't need to point out that we are the government and we are here to do this job, right? It needs to happen by complete autonomy, if possible.

(45:52 - 46:14)

I'll give you a simple example. If you go to land in most places on earth, you're going to see that you land, you are greeted by an officer with a gun sitting across a counter with a bulletproof glass in front of them and you feel intimidated. And they look at you with this very intimidating look and they look at your passport.

(46:15 - 46:31)

Some countries are a bit more friendly, but generally speaking, it's a very intimidating experience. Why did the UAE decide to offer a service, which you can try, by the way, if you visit here often, to offer a service of smart gate where you don't have to deal with a single person. You just walk across the airport.

(46:31 - 46:41)

You don't even have to pull out your passport, right? As a government, we're doing our job in the

background. You are getting the best in class service. Can other governments do it? Absolutely.

(46:42 - 46:56)

We believe that our job is to do our work and give you the best in class service possible. And this is why you're seeing here that government doesn't interfere. Government doesn't have to be something that you interact with if you don't need to interact with.

(46:56 - 47:06)

We are here to offer the service that you need to get. But it just doesn't stay with the government and let's say the role of government. It's true for infrastructure.

(47:06 - 47:33)

People don't care, you know, how many people are working on this road, or how much I spent on this road, or how the road looks like. They care about the quality of the roads, right? We are upgrading the infrastructure every single day. And the fact why we're doing it is because we understand the quality of life improvement is huge, right? So when people can go and live anywhere on earth, for them to choose to live here, means that this system is a system that is universal.

(47:34 - 47:48)

And it's not a system that is a system of a rich country versus a poor country or a big country versus a small country. There are countries that are in a much better situation than we are in. So if you look at Libya, for example, Libya has a population of around 8 million.

(47:48 - 47:57)

So they're not very large homogeneous population. One of the richest countries in the world because of natural resources. Today, you can go to Libya.

(47:57 - 48:07)

It's a war-torn country. So what they lacked is a secret ingredient, which is good leadership. And I think we always discount the impact that leaders have.

(48:07 - 48:18)

But I believe the most important thing for any country is really good leaders. I think that's incredible. The no government interference, no intimidation.

(48:21 - 48:38)

I can see that when I go through the airport and I think it makes a big difference. For example,

when I'm going to a Western country or coming here, the difference is fairly stark. The tax arbitrage also plays a big role as to why people come here and you think that will stay forever.

(48:40 - 49:08)

I know you have corporate taxes now, but you don't have capital gains or income tax really. If people from other countries continue to move here to take advantage of that tax treatment, they're not essentially earning their income in this country, but spending their money here almost. Do you think that could go on? Why do we have taxes in the first place? Great thought, I agree with you.

(49:08 - 49:12)

I wish they weren't. No, no, I don't think there should be or shouldn't be. We have to understand the purpose.

(49:12 - 49:24)

The purpose of the tax is to balance the budget. At the end of the day, you have to invest and you have to spend. So you have the capital expenditure that you need to spend on for your infrastructure development or new sectors or so on and so forth.

(49:25 - 49:35)

And then you have the operational expenses that you have to do with salaries and so on and so forth. So if you are a bloated government, you will need more taxes. So you will find different domains to collect as much tax as possible.

(49:36 - 49:55)

If you are a lean government, you will actually spend more on investment rather than on your operations. If you are a government that tries to diversify your streams of income, you can offer the most favorable regime. So we as a government today have diverse streams of income.

(49:55 - 50:12)

Today, VAT is 5% in the UAE. And the more people consume, the more income there is for the government. It's great, right? So instead of actually making you pay capital gains tax, the fact that from your 5% VAT, I can make a killing as a government and make a big return and balance my budget is great.

(50:13 - 50:44)

The same is true as well for all the sectors that the government has gone in where the focus is in the UAE, the sovereign wealth funds, where the focus is global. The government-related entities

that are global in nature, whether it's the port operators, the airport operators, the airlines, the banks, we always throughout our history have never thought of ourselves and confined ourselves to our geographical boundaries. We always believe that we can be a global player in anything we do.

(50:45 - 51:15)

And with that, we're able to create streams of revenue where others are looking at challenges that they can't overcome. And this is the thing. If you understand the principle of something, so why do taxes exist? If you understand why and you understand the fundamentals of it, you'll be able to create a regime that works for all parties involved, where those who come here can take home a big portion of their income, where the government can balance its budget, and where the investments can be made for the quality of life to be better for everyone.

(51:16 - 51:36)

No, fair point. I think the only point where I could contest there is for a lot of these people. For a lot of these people, say, coming from India, for example, or coming from different pockets, the tax that they're not paying is not on income earned here.

(51:36 - 52:04)

They're earning the income in other countries. The profits are registered here, and then they don't end up paying tax, even if the budgets of the country where they're actually earning the income is not balanced. So that's actually changing with the OECD Pillar 2 structure that's coming into effect, where you have to pay the corporate tax at the country that you are generating the income from.

(52:05 - 52:24)

So for him to pay himself, or for that person to pay themselves, they need to first pay the corporate taxes, and then distribute the dividends. So I think the country that they're operating in, where most of the wealth is actually generated, will have to actually generate some sort of return from their business enterprise. So I think that's going to be overcome.

(52:25 - 52:46)

The reality of the matter is, you can't get it right for everyone, for every country, and for yourself. Today, we are doing what suits the people here, what suits our budgets, what suits our system. And we won't come and preach that this is the right model for everyone.

(52:46 - 53:08)

Again, it's good to understand that we are in a position to do that today. Most people look at this,

and they say they can afford to do this because of oil revenue. A city like Dubai has no oil revenue, right? So Dubai has creative ways of balancing its budgets, of making investments, of growing as an economy.

(53:09 - 53:41)

And this is the thing, when you have good people running the government that think of ingenious ways to always diversify, to always cover whatever gap might exist, they'll be able to find solutions where everyone wins, not one party or one specific demographic. For a long time, I've heard rumors of a MAT, like a Minimum Alternative Tax, pushed largely by Western countries where they are seeing the migration out of. Say, for example, the UK has a lot of people moving here now.

(53:42 - 54:21)

Do you think the world will come together and at some point have something like a MAT where immaterial of what country you are and where in the world you have to pay a 15 or 20% tax? I think the right way to go about this and answer this question is we need to organize a meeting between you and our Minister of Finance who can give you more details on this. I'm not sure if it will work. Personally, speaking from my vantage point, I don't understand how these global deals when it comes to taxes are put together and how much leeway you have as a singular government or a bloc is possible, especially in dealing with these Western countries.

(54:21 - 55:08)

So I don't want to give you an answer where I'm not sure how it's going to play out. But what I will say is whether you pay tax somewhere or not, what people really care about is if I am actually investing my time, my effort and my hard-earned income in this country, what am I getting in return? What is the quality of education? What is the quality of hospitals? What's the quality of infrastructure? What is the quality of the business environment? And as long as the answer is it's high quality and the impact is positive and net positive for the individual, then it's great. When the answer is it's actually negative and you're spending money but you're not getting anything in return from your government, the answer is always going to be something where there's an issue of sustainability there because people are going to get frustrated at one point of time.

(55:09 - 55:32)

And Omar, if I may ask, we left the part between school and how did you become a minister at the age of 27 after not having come from a political family to a father who was in the army and a mother who was a principal. Were you a good student? So this is a wide ranging discussion which I love. We're going into philosophy and politics and other things and taxes.

(55:33 - 55:46)

So I was a good student. I was a nerd, as you can tell, in school. So there were a few things that happened between school, university and work.

(55:46 - 56:12)

The first thing was I really wanted to study abroad. So I wanted to go to Harvard after finishing school and that didn't work out because my mother at the time felt like it's better for me to stay close for two reasons. 9-11 happened a few years earlier and there were hate crimes against Arabs and Muslims in the US which really struck a chord with her.

(56:12 - 56:25)

She felt like if we go there, someone might target us for whatever reason. So she said, I'd rather you stay home. The second reason was, the world was going through so much turmoil.

(56:25 - 56:50)

So I graduated in 2007 and I went to university but at that time you could feel like there was something that was off. So our stock market boomed and then dropped and then started booming again and people felt like, okay, there might be something lurking in the horizon. So there was a sense of optimism and pessimism.

(56:50 - 57:12)

So my mother and my father were saying, it's better that you are close rather than you go abroad. The second thing is I decided with them that if I were to stay and study here, that I will work and study. And the reason why I wanted to work and study is because I felt like I wanted to understand what comes after studying and to understand what the business environment was like.

(57:13 - 57:41)

This was one of the best decisions of my life and one of the most painful decisions of my life because I decided to work in a bank during the merger of two of the largest banks, so Emirates Bank and NBD. So I was actually working between these two banks while the merger was taking place and then the financial crisis struck. And I got to see firsthand what happens to the world when there's a financial crisis.

(57:42 - 58:12)

I got to see firsthand the way the world changes from euphoria to complete terror, from tomorrow being a good day to people packing up their stuff and leaving, you know, feeling like their life is completely destroyed. And I was working in something called the Retail Credit Center, where people actually apply for loans and they would get the loans. So it was a devastating experience.

(58:13 - 58:30)

But it was a grounding experience. I understood that we should never take today for granted. No matter what the situation is, we should understand that we are privileged in the situation we are in and we need to work 100 times harder than everyone else to be able to deserve the place we are in.

(58:30 - 58:47)

I left university after I graduated. I graduated with a degree in business management and I was a great economics student. I actually loved economics and wanted to pursue a master's degree in economics.

(58:48 - 59:04)

So I started a business venture, a distribution company, because I believed that I should do something there. My father told me the only way to get by in life is to get a pension. And he said, if you don't have a pension, you don't have a safety net.

(59:05 - 59:31)

So I told him, Dad, if you believe that this is what I need to be doing, tell me where you want me to work and I'll work. As long as it makes you happy, I'll do it. So he applied for me to go and work in something called the telecommunications regulations authority, where a spectrum regulation is done for the telecom operators, signal distribution is given to all the different entities that require signal.

(59:34 - 59:49)

And an interesting thing happened. So in the job interview, I was sitting across the table from a few folks. And they said to me, where do you see yourself in five years? I told them I see myself as a minister.

(59:52 - 59:59)

And they laughed. And they said, we like the confidence. This is what I see.

(59:59 - 1:00:16)

I might be wrong. But if I really pursue this, and if I choose to stay in the job, I think I'm going to become a minister. And they said, what makes you think that you're going to get the job? I told them, I don't know if I'm going to get the job.

(1:00:16 - 1:00:26)

I know I'm going to be the hardest working employee here. And I know that I'm going to learn the job faster than anyone else. And I got the job.

(1:00:26 - 1:00:47)

And there was a deal that was struck. And the deal was that they're going to give me the job and then see post my probation how well I do. And I told them, whenever you assess me, if I turn out to be a good employee, I would love to be able to go and work in the ITU headquarters in Geneva.

(1:00:48 - 1:00:59)

And I wanted to go and work in Geneva for two reasons. The first is because I wanted to pursue a master's in Geneva. And the second is whenever you're stationed abroad, you're able to experience life outside your country.

(1:00:59 - 1:01:11)

And I think that's worth a lot of value for any person. So the assessment was done. I passed the assessment.

(1:01:11 - 1:01:18)

I turned out to be a good employee. They said, well done. And then they said to me, well, we'll send you in two years.

(1:01:18 - 1:01:28)

We sent someone else. We didn't think you're going to make it. And I felt that maybe, you know, I can't really stay in this place.

(1:01:28 - 1:01:33)

So I wanted to resign. I told a few friends. I decided to resign.

(1:01:34 - 1:01:47)

The interesting thing is the following week, out of the blue, I got a phone call. And they told me, we have a few questions to ask you. Please answer these questions.

(1:01:48 - 1:01:52)

I told them what this is for. They said it's just relating to an interview for a job. I told them I didn't apply anywhere.

(1:01:53 - 1:02:04)

They said, yes, but we have a few questions. So the question was, how many people are in Dubai Mall right now? And I remember it was a Tuesday morning. And I came up with a number.

(1:02:04 - 1:02:21)

I gave them the logic for why I came up with that number. And they said to me, okay, how many people are in the cinema of Dubai Mall right now? I thought that was very odd. I came up with the logic.

(1:02:22 - 1:02:29)

Kids are in school. People are in their jobs. Tourists probably will go to the cinema, but there are these number of tourists potentially, et cetera, et cetera.

(1:02:30 - 1:02:33)

Great. Thank you very much. And the person hung up.

(1:02:34 - 1:02:52)

Having worked in the Telecom Regulations Authority, I understood that in most offices, they have IP phones. And IP phones, if you change the last two digits to 00 or 99, the reception answers. So I called the number with 99 at the end.

(1:02:53 - 1:03:04)

And the woman answered and she said, Prime Minister's office, can I help you? I said, yes, hello. Thank you for answering. I got a phone call from the following extension and the line got dropped.

(1:03:04 - 1:03:10)

Can you please connect me to him? And she said, yes, this was Othman. I'll connect you to him. So she connected me to Othman.

(1:03:12 - 1:03:17)

And Othman, when I called him, he said, hello, Othman, this is Omar. You just called me. You hung up.

(1:03:17 - 1:03:28)

Why didn't you tell me that you're calling from the Prime Minister's office? I said, how do you know my name? I told him. And he said, you have an interview next week. So I got the interview and they gave me a job offer.

(1:03:28 - 1:03:40)

When I worked in Abu Dhabi, my salary was around $10,000. When I got the offer in the Prime Minister's office, it was nearly half. So I came to my mother.

(1:03:40 - 1:03:48)

I told her, mom, I got this offer in Dubai. I'm not sure I'm going to take it. What do you think? And I still remember what she said to me.

(1:03:48 - 1:04:06)

She said, Omar, there are certain places where you'd only work if they pay you. There are other places where you are willing to pay to work for them. And she said, working for Sheikh Mohammed and working for the government, even if they ask you to pay your own salary, you should be willing to do that.

(1:04:07 - 1:04:29)

So I got the job after accepting. And the first thing I realized was working for Sheikh Mohammed in the Prime Minister's office was one of the toughest and most rewarding jobs you can ever get anywhere in the world. The first thing about this job was we had to learn to do everything.

(1:04:30 - 1:04:39)

So it's not a job where you were only asked to do one specific thing. Anything and everything you had to learn and you had to do it. It was a small team.

(1:04:39 - 1:05:10)

So being on the outside, hearing about Sheikh Mohammed, hearing about the government and what is happening, I assume there are thousands and thousands and thousands of people going into the office seeing this very lean team that's very efficient, where people have skills in many different domains, where they're unified with one goal. And the one goal is, you know, what we're doing here is impacting the lives of millions of people. And we need to make sure that our country is the best, our government is the best, was energizing.

(1:05:12 - 1:05:28)

And this was really the school in which I grew up in. All right, this was like the first experience of a true job. With that, the first thing I will say, and this, by the way, is something that I'm proud of.

(1:05:31 - 1:05:47)

Most of the employees in the office would go into the office at 8am and would leave the office at 10pm every single day. We would work on weekends. We were pouring our hearts out into the jobs.

(1:05:48 - 1:06:02)

With that, we also got a very interesting thing from His Highness directly. So His Highness didn't believe that you need to be a certain age to do something. He didn't believe that, you know, there are these chosen people or the righteous people.

(1:06:02 - 1:06:16)

He gave everyone a chance. And I remember he gave me, at 25 years old, a responsibility. There was a platform that the UAE started called the World Government Summit.

(1:06:16 - 1:06:33)

It was a very, very big deal. Prime Ministers, CEOs, heads of state, heads of NGOs from around the world come to this. And it's a very, very important convening.

(1:06:34 - 1:06:49)

And I got a phone call from Minister Gargawi, and he said, Sheikh Mohammed is going to appoint you as the person who's going to run the summit. I told him, Your Excellency, it's a very big deal. Like, there's a lot of things that can go wrong.

(1:06:49 - 1:07:00)

And I'm just 25. Are you sure I'm the right person? And he said, His Highness doesn't believe that it's about your age. He believes that it's about your ability, your grit, your perseverance.

(1:07:01 - 1:07:07)

And he said, we're all behind you. We're not going to let you fail. Put in your heart.

(1:07:08 - 1:07:13)

Make the best out of this. And let's see what you can do. So I worked on the summit.

(1:07:15 - 1:07:50)

I think I was lucky enough to have been able to be part of that team and to enact some change there. And the summit today is one of the most incredible platforms in the world, where you have over 30 heads of state, where you have thousands of CEOs from Elon Musk to Larry Ellison to CEOs from India and others, and where you have the world coming together to talk about a positive future in government. People always look at government and they think of government as bureaucracy, as red tape, as slow, as old-fashioned.

(1:07:51 - 1:08:01)

This is the only place where you come and people are talking about government in a very positive light. And they're talking about pragmatic ways to improve government. So I was given that task.

(1:08:01 - 1:08:13)

I delivered on it. Then I was given another task to run the largest drone race in the world. I knew nothing about drones.

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So I worked on a project called the World Drone Prix. It actually set the benchmark globally for drone races. It was the largest at the time.

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So we had to create new things that weren't there. So the first thing that we did, I remember seeing drone races. You can't really tell what the speed of the drone is unless you put the odometer there with the speed.

(1:08:38 - 1:08:51)

And I told them that we need to make people feel like they're very, very fast. On the road, you are able to tell what the speed is by seeing the lines on the road. So I told the team, let's actually create something where the racetrack looks like a skeleton.

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So there are like these bones, there's a straight white track, and there are these things, we call them the wings, that come out of it. And it looks like a big skeleton. And as the drone flies through it, the sense of speed increases.

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So you feel like they're going, you know, three, four times faster than they're actually going. After that, I was given another task. I was asked to work on strategies for the government.

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I was asked to work on so many different projects here and there. And then I was supposed to go to military service. Before going to military service, there was a person who submitted a strategy for the UAE on AI.

(1:09:34 - 1:10:08)

Now you have to understand first, why did we work on a strategy for AI? The reason why we worked on it is His Highness Sheikh Mohammed bin Zayed, the president, at the time he was the

Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi, gave a speech at the World Government Summit, and he spoke about the UAE celebrating the exporting of the last barrel of oil. And he said, if the decisions we take today are the right decisions, we're going to celebrate exporting the last barrel of oil. And he said, we need to invest in the sectors that are going to transform the world.

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And he talked about a vision. So typically, the way that our government runs is we don't hear something interesting and say, oh, this is interesting and move on. We hear something interesting and we say, what do we do about it? So His Highness Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid, the prime minister, heard that speech and he said, let's actually work on a strategy to benefit from these sectors.

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So we worked on it. We called it the Centennial Strategy. And within that strategy, there was a big focus on AI.

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So some people that we consulted thought that they can actually work on a strategy. I was asked to comment on the strategy. I was a person who liked to read about these things.

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I was passionate about AI and technology. So I saw the strategy that they had. And the strategy, I think, was short-sighted.

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It was a Western view with Western problems and Western ideologies applied to the UAE. I'll give you a simple example. So the view was, you know, we should deploy AI across all sectors in the next three years.

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At that time, AI wasn't LLMs. It wasn't agents. AI was computer vision.

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AI was recommendation engines. And self-driving cars, you know, we need to put an ambitious target in three years. Self-driving cars need to be everywhere.

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And I was asked to review that strategy. So I reviewed it. And I had so many comments.

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Some of the comments were, self-driving cars still haven't reached where they want to reach. It's going to come. But we shouldn't say that we're going to do it in three years when the technology is not something we can control.

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The second thing is, we need to understand the impact of AI on the jobs in the UAE. And third is, we need to start the first level of deploying the strategy by focusing on building the skill sets and the talents locally and attracting talent from abroad and getting the ecosystem ready for what's to come. So I submitted this.

(1:12:21 - 1:12:27)

I got married. I went on my honeymoon. On the third day of my honeymoon, I got a phone call.

(1:12:27 - 1:12:48)

Can I ask how did you decide who you married? So as you would assume from Indian marriages, there's a lot of pressure from my mother. And I think, you know, definitely she saw things when it came to marriage. She understood it was the right time even before I did.

(1:12:49 - 1:13:14)

I always wanted to get married, even at a young age. The only issue with marriage is, and I don't want to get too philosophical here, but I think that marriage feels like a big burden. But once you take that leap of faith, you realize it's a beautiful synergy of two people that can take on any problem, that can go through any task and figure it out together.

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So my mother actually kept telling me, you know, you should think about it. And I decided it was the right time. And that actually worked out.

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So on the third day of my honeymoon, I got a phone call. And the phone call was, Hello Omar, book the next flight back. And my response was, if you don't tell me why, I'll come back single.

(1:13:37 - 1:13:48)

I'm currently married. So if you don't give me the reason why, I'm going to come back single. And

the response was, you're going to find out in a few hours, book the next flight back.

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So I changed my flight. I didn't tell my wife. I was anxious.

(1:13:54 - 1:14:07)

At around 7pm, I think it was 7 or 8pm Tokyo time, because we were in Tokyo in Japan. The announcement came out that I became minister of AI. And I was 27 at the time.

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Now, so it was a blessing. You know, it still is an honor. And I hope to be able to earn that trust that I was given at the time.

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Amazing. When it comes to governance, if I were to say, start with corruption, God, in a way can be God-like because he gets the validation of being God, the validation and devotion of being God. So if you're a minister, or the president, or the prime minister, or the ruler of one region or another, I think there's a lot of devotion and validation that comes with the chair that you sit on.

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That could feed into some kind of altruism, maybe. But if you're not in that position and you're going down the chain, the deputy of that person, the deputy of the deputy, the people who are at the bottom, working on the ground, for a country that has developed as quickly as it has, because I've been coming to this region now for maybe a decade or two, how do you deal with it? I feel like all people at the very core are self-serving. If somebody is not getting the validation and devotion that comes from being in public life, they are working towards meeting a capitalistic end.

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And somebody who's meeting a capitalistic end, how do you get someone like that to not be corrupt and for projects to finish efficiently and on time? So I'm going to answer this in three ways. The first is, there's an Arabic saying, which is people are as their kings are. And what it actually means, if the king is a tyrant, then people will be people who actually apply tyranny in their society.

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If the king is corrupt, people are going to be corrupt. If the king is generous, people are going to be generous. There's something that in our culture we believe in.

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And the first thing is, if there is corruption at the top, there will be corruption at the bottom. At the end of the day, it's as simple as that. Because whatever rules you apply on yourself, people will apply on themselves as well.

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So I think this is maybe the basic principle that is important to understand. You can't claim to be combating corruption if you're siphoning money for your family or for your people or for whoever you think deserves that money. The second thing I'm going to say is, why are people corrupt? So what is the fundamentals of corruption? The fundamentals of corruption are three things.

(1:17:12 - 1:17:23)

The first is that people actually are going to get away from it or get away with it. They think that I'm going to do it, no one's going to catch me. The second is, they feel like they are cheated.

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So I'm not getting as much as I deserve. So I'm going to take matters into my own hands. And the third is, the purpose in which they are there is a selfish one rather than a noble one.

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To combat this, there is a very hard line that is drawn when it comes to certain things like corruption. So it is not tolerated at all. And when people are chosen to work in government here, and when people are chosen for leadership positions here, this is one of the values that are seen.

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Like, you need to be someone who's doing it for the right reasons. You are driven to do the right things. The second thing is, people are well paid here.

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So I think the UAE government in terms of ministerial positions is amongst the highest in terms of monthly pay in the world. So I think Singapore is higher, a few other countries are maybe higher. But we get paid quite well.

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And why we get paid well is because, you know, if you ask His Highness to tell you this, if you're expecting me to hire someone who can also get a job as being the CEO of a company, or being an entrepreneur, or being the best of the best in his field, I need to pay him what he would get

being in that position. If you pay peanuts, you get monkeys, right? If you pay very small amounts and expect to get the best people, there is a challenge there. And in certain countries, we see that they find other ways of making money.

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It's not right, but at the end of the day, that's the model that appears in those countries. And then the final thing is, when people believe that they are treated fairly, that the system is built to ensure that everyone prospers together, where recognition is given when you deserve recognition, where you don't sit on that seat because you are the son of someone, or because you went through a certain journey in life and you need to be there. You earn that seat and you work 10 times harder than everyone else to stay on that seat.

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You see that there is no need for them to apply the corrupt mindset that exists in other places. This is at the top. Now at the bottom, there's always some form of corruption applied in different domains at the bottom.

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The first thing you need to do is you need to have constant checks and balances to ensure that there is no corruption. And with that, I may have mentioned in the past that His Highness Sheikh Mohammed has what he calls secret choppers. So these are people that go across town, they look like me, they might look like you, who raise reports to him, who tell him, for example, that they've witnessed corruption here or inefficiency there or they identify talent there.

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And with that, certain actions are taken to eradicate this corruption or to elevate this talent or to do certain things related to what was witnessed. The second thing is there needs to be government systems that constantly look at where these inefficiencies exist and to remove that red tape. So we have a government initiative called Zero Bureaucracy.

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For Zero Bureaucracy, every year, we try to reduce 50% of bureaucracy in our government. It's a lot. 50% year on year.

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So you reduce inefficiencies, you reduce inefficiencies, you reduce red tape, you reduce corruption, you reduce all the things related to it, and you become more efficient with time. The secret chopper thing seems like a great idea, by the way. It's easier said than done.

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Yeah? What are the issues with it? The secret choppers themselves might be corrupt. So, okay, how do you identify a secret chopper? If they know the power that they wield, if they understand that they can raise something to you and a decision will be taken, then they could be corrupt or they can support a certain party over another. There are so many things that they can do.

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Now, the choice of a secret chopper is, I think, the art that the science Sheikh Mohammed Ibn Rashid implemented. Identifying people and identifying checks and balances on them as well to understand how these people are always going to raise the right things. There are always constantly people that are either removed from that overall group of people.

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But, you know, the need to always constantly inject new blood, remove old blood that, for example, might go in the wrong direction, but also ensure that there is validation on the reports that they're raising. Like, okay, someone might say, this is good. If you don't check and you just take an action on it, you might take the wrong decision, right? So, if I may ask you, Your Excellency, for a country with 11 million people, 10 million expats and one Emirati, a lot of the expats are Indians and Bangladeshis and Pakistanis and so on and so forth.

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I know so many people who live here who are Indian. When you look from the lens of policy making, whose country is it? Are you making policies based on 11 million people or 1 million people? So, why does it have to be a choice of is it the 1 million or is it the 11 million or is it the Indians or the Bangladeshis or whatever demographic lives here? What people really care about, and this you see, by the way, in the US, right? When they talk about the American dream, what is the American dream? The American dream is that I can work hard and I can achieve prosperity. It's that I will be given equal opportunity.

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It's that I'm going to be safe. I'm going to be able to live like everyone else. And I think this is the essence of it.

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Now, the country is the country of the 1 million. At the end of the day, those are the people that are going to serve in the army. Those are the people that are going to stay here regardless through thick and thin, right? But the moment you differentiate is the moment you lose.

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And this is what makes this place special is that people don't feel the differentiation. I can wear a kandora or wear shorts and a t-shirt and act like an Indian in the streets. I'm going to get the same treatment.

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I can act like a European, you know, bleach my hair or change the color and I'll be treated equally. And I think this is what all governments should strive to do. It needs to be a government where it takes care of its people, those who are representative of who put that government, but also serves everyone equally.

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As the AI minister, if you were to paint the world of tomorrow, five years from now, how do you see it from the lens of technology? Tomorrow or five years from now, the answer to me is, I think technology is going to be pervasive. It's going to be completely invisible. It's going to be everywhere, but it's not going to be in our faces.

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We will see certain elements of it. So we are going to see robots. We are going to see autonomous vehicles.

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We are going to see certain places where technology is going to be a bit more prevalent. But the same way that electricity today runs through many things and nearly everything in our lives, whether it's in our devices, whether it's in our lighting, whether it's in the way we cook our food or, you know, we manage our affairs. I think AI is going to be everywhere.

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And with that, with that level of intelligence, we will be able to, you know, outsource many decisions. I don't know if that's a positive thing, but many decisions are going to be outsourced to the machines. And the quality of life improvement will be an order of magnitude improvement compared to the lives we live today.

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So you will spend time, brainpower, effort on the things you really choose to spend time and effort on. And many other things, as long as they can be done in the right way, the way that you like it, and you can outsource it to the machine, you're going to do it. That's what I think is going to

happen.

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If AI gets better at decision making than people, would you outsource policy decision making to AI? There are examples of countries that are looking at this. The question is always whether AI can make good or good new decisions versus build on historical data and take decisions accordingly. I'll give you a simple example.

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So there was a question, if you feed AI all of the information of physics up until 1910, can it come up with the theory of relativity? Can it? I've read this, so I know the answer is no, but... So there are those who say no. And some people actually try to simulate this. There are those who say yes.

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If the answer is no, and all the answers point to it's not being able to do that, then it can't take policy decisions because on many things relating to policy, there are new things you're dealing with. So there has to be decisions that are built on unknowns, right? But I think there is going to be this beautiful harmony of man and machine where you'll be able to simulate things, crunch data, and then the humans take the policy decisions related to the new things that emerge. The one thing this region has done extremely well, which to me looks like it has led to its prosperity as well, is in a region which is surrounded by conflict, it has always stayed out of conflict.

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And I've been having meetings here in Dubai this week. You see Chinese, you see Russian, you see strangely so much conversation about UAE's connection with Africa and all the businesses that people are doing there. So you're friends with the US, you're friends with Russia, you're friends with China, you're also friends with India and Africa and so on and so forth.

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How do you manage to not take a side in a world which is so polarized and binary with every passing day? It's very difficult. And I'm going to maybe say a few things first relating to our history. So if you know the history of this country and you know the history of this region, so our country has always been a point where the world comes to do business, to meet, to build together.

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4,000 years ago, there's a location that's around 20 kilometers in this direction called Saruq al-

Hadid. It's an archaeological site that was unearthed. And what was interesting about it is they unearthed both artifacts and let's say gold and copper and other artifacts from the Egyptian civilization and the Indian civilization.

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So most archaeologists and historians say that this is where the Egyptians and the Indians used to trade 4,000 years ago. If you fast forward 200 years ago, this was still a place where East and West used to trade. Today, it's still a place where North, South, East and West do business.

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So we are a country that thrives on openness. We are a people that welcome it, that live it, that breathe it. If you look at all of the merchants and the big traders that came out of the UAE from the 19th century to the 20th century to the 21st century, they never focused on the UAE.

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They were always global traders that traded with the world from the UAE that did business with India, that did business with China, that did business with Africa and with the broader Middle East. So this is how we are and we will always promote it. We will always promote that we are a beacon of collaboration, a beacon of cooperation, a beacon of trade and prosperity hopefully for the world.

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Now, there are so many differences in the world. I think there is a need for us to have dialogue. There is a need for us in the world to have a patron of at least some sort of middle ground.

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I'll give you an example. At the height of the Cold War, there were discussions between the Americans and the Russians about nuclear bombs, about safeguards, about what is happening in this domain and how it's going to affect people. That was at the height of the Cold War, right? Today, we can't afford to let the technologies that we're working on, whether it's biotech, whether it's AI, whether it's technology that can cross borders today because of digital infrastructure that connects us or the open borders that we have around the world to go wrong anywhere on earth.

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So we need to have a patron of dialogue, a patron of cooperation. It doesn't mean that I will choose the benefit of China over the UK or the benefit of Russia over Ukraine. The Russians and the Ukrainians both know that I'm going to be a fair conduit for both, that I'm going to work with both equally, that I'm not going to do something to harm one over the other.

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And I think the world needs more examples of that. It needs more examples of countries like the UAE that they try to build bridges where we are seeing a world where bridges and roads are being dismantled and dialogues are completely ending. Very well said.

(1:32:34 - 1:32:58)

From the lens of technology and blockchain, this region has become some kind of hub for everything crypto, Bitcoin. Up until recently, it looked like the government was really pushing for it. I might not be the best person to be reading into it, but is the government changing their stance on it? We haven't.

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We've been working on blockchain technology since 2015. And we've gone through it through people thinking it was a bubble, people thinking it was over. And we've looked at the fundamentals.

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And we've always been a supportive government of technological innovation, but not overly blinded by the technology. You always have to try to strike a balance. And I think the stance is always going to be that.

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The stance is always going to be supportive of technology, but not blinded by it. So, Omar, I play paddle. I know everybody plays paddle in Dubai.

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I play paddle back home in India. And my teammate is an 18-year-old boy called Deon, who's significantly better than I. He would blindfolded with a fracture on one hand, he would beat me. I'm saying he's that good.

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Or your game is that bad. It's one of the two. Yeah, I think a little bit of both, maybe.

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So, the thing I really appreciate with Deon, and I play with other kids his age, restraint is very attractive in somebody that young. So one day I played paddle with Deon. I went back home and I'm like, there's such an impressive kid.

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He has restraint, even though he's 18. You as a politician at 35 seem to exercise restraint in the right measure. At some point as you age, restraint will no longer be cool and action or impulse will become cool.

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And I think this switch happens in every man's life, depending on what age he is. As a politician, outside of what you believe philosophically and as a representation of your country, who are you as a person and where are you at? What's on the other side, if there is one? I really don't know how to answer this question because every person sees themselves in a certain way, right? I might see certain good things. Others might be seeing certain bad things.

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What I genuinely believe is you can't act. So the truth is always going to come out and your job is to be who you are and to do what not just people expect of you, but what best you can do. Sometimes people expect a lot of things.

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If you can't do it, you have to be honest and say, I can't do it. When it comes to impulse versus restraint, I don't think it's about either impulse or restraint. I think it's about wisdom.

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It's about assessing the situation and knowing where you need to exercise impulse, where you need to move fast and actually take action and move, where you need to exercise restraint, where you need to talk, where you need to be quiet. And, you know, with age, I would say the reality is the other way around. You tend to be impulsive with age because you feel like the world is your oyster, as they say.

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There's a lot that you have to prove. And that you want to prove that you're the smartest or you're the best or, you know, the most or whatever it is. And having the wisdom to understand and maybe going back to the Dunning-Kruger effect to understand that sometimes it's actually better just to take it all in.

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Your job is not to speak. Your job is to absorb. Sometimes your job is to stand up for what's right.

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And here impulse actually makes sense. Sometimes your job is to respond. Sometimes your job is to absorb, right? Whether it's in conflict, whether it's in good times or bad times, you know, there's a saying that says, don't make promises when you're happy.

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Don't make decisions when you're sad. And I think wisdom is many of those kinds of things. All right.

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And what we need in the world is we need more wisdom. I don't think it's about restraint. A restraint is like a spring.

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You keep pressuring yourself to hold back. One day, as you said, men fluctuate between the two. If it truly is restraint, the spring is going to push back against the hand that's pushing it down, right? And if it's about impulse, one day people are not wanting to deal with you.

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So I think it's a balance. Wisdom is the most important thing. We're in the last part of this.

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If I don't ask you a question and ask you, what is one thing you want to talk about, but usually do not because you're worried how it will come across if you talk about it? This is a Peter Thiel question, right? He asks it in interviews. One thing that I want to talk about, but I'm worried about how people perceive it. So personally, as a person, and you probably will see this with time, I believe that you should be open and talk about anything and everything you want to talk about as long as you understand enough of the topic and as long as you can defend what you believe in, right? And if you can't, if the other person can convince you, great.

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You learned something new. One thing that I don't typically talk about that I should talk about is people look at the world and they don't talk about the things that actually matter at times. They talk about the things that are fashionable, right? So we look at the situation of the world and we see devastation in certain places.

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We see sometimes economic models that are leading to bad results. And the thing is, okay, let's not talk about affordable housing. Let's talk about another topic that might be relevant for this

point of time, but isn't relevant for the 7 billion people or the 6 billion people that are suffering from that specific issue, right? And what saddens me is, and I think this is getting rectified, for a long period of time, if you talked about one of these topics, you're going to be canceled.

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So if you talk about, for example, you know, we spoke today about political systems. I don't believe that I need to export my political system to you and I genuinely believe that you shouldn't be coming to export your political system to me, right? As long as the system is benefiting the people, then it's great. At a point of time, this was a taboo subject.

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You can't talk about it. We are proud of what we have here. We are proud of our history.

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We are proud of our people. We are proud of the prosperity that we are creating. And I think it doesn't mean that because we are succeeding that other people are, you know, being harmed by it or they're being attacked by it.

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And we need to have dialogue in the world. I do something that I'll share with you. I'm sorry, I'm losing my voice.

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So we'll try to edit that the right way. I do something where I host gatherings. So I like to read and I host a gathering that's like a book club.

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And I tell the people that come to these gatherings, let's have discussions and let's talk openly about different subjects. And I actually want to learn. And this curiosity is important.

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It's very important for the curiosity and the right type of content to be available for everyone. You see, for a long period of time, there was algorithmic muting for certain content. So you couldn't say certain things about Gaza, for example, right? And then because of the pressure, people started to talk about it.

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We need to be able to have dialogue. We need to be able to understand what is truly happening.

And I think we need to ensure that people have exposure to the right things.

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That's one thing that I don't talk about publicly. But I think today the discourse is a lot more welcoming of this kind of dialogue than it was in the past. I agree with you 100%.

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I think the world is lacking one thing, if it's one thing only, it's discourse. Whenever somebody doesn't agree with your opinion, they get offended and they really should not. Actually, I have a better answer to that question.

(1:42:10 - 1:42:21)

Can I repeat it? Please. Okay. One thing I believe in, that people are going to judge me if I say, but I will say it, tennis is better than paddle tennis.

(1:42:23 - 1:42:36)

It's a better sport, but paddle tennis is fun. I think people are going to migrate from being paddle tennis players to tennis players if they're able to build a fitness. Now I know I'm speaking with a tennis player.

(1:42:38 - 1:42:47)

But thank you so much, Your Excellency for doing this. This was a lot of fun and hope to catch up with you again soon. Absolutely.

(1:42:47 - 1:42:49)

Looking forward to it and thank you for having me. Thank you.